

Embracing my inner cyber wizard to defeat Impostor Syndrome



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Embracing my inner cyber wizard to defeat impostor syndrome ~ @vgzbrennan@infosec.exchange

Summary

- Impostor Syndrome Deep Dive
- IS in IS (Rants abound)
- Hacker Grimoire Origins
- Lessons Learned

TL;DW*:

Disclaimer slide

I am here to represent myself and my own opinions. The statements made and opinions expressed in this presentation do not necessarily represent those of the Virginia College Savings Plan or the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Also, I'm pretty dumb, and while I tried my best to make sure everything was accurate, It's definitely possible I've omitted something important.

whoami

- Been in InfoSec my entire professional career.
 - Been in a SOC, CIRT, Customer Engineering, System Engineering...
- Interest in it has been significantly longer than that
 - Amateur Infosec/hacker culture historian
- Giant effing Nerd
 - Vidya gamez (shoutout to vgz.cx)
 - Animoo
 - Sci-Fi
 - 3d Printing
 - 90s tech, laptops, PDAs, etc.



Return of the disclaimer slide!

- As I just stated in the previous slide, I am not a doctor or trained in Psychology
- Talk to experts
- Therapy is great
 - Most Health Insurances cover or help cover the costs of therapy
 - psychologytoday.com is a great resource



Let's talk about impostor syndrome



Introducing Impostor Syndrome

From the National Institutes of Health:

“Impostor Syndrome is a behavioral health phenomenon described as self-doubt of intellect, skills, or accomplishments among high-achieving individuals. These individuals cannot internalize their success and subsequently experience pervasive feelings of self-doubt, anxiety, depression, and/or apprehension of being exposed as a fraud in their work, despite verifiable and objective evidence of their successfulness.”

History of Impostor Syndrome

- First written about in a Psychology Journal in 1978 by Drs. Pauline Rose Clance & Suzanne Imes
 - Gained more widespread notoriety due to the book *The Impostor Phenomenon: When Success Makes You Feel Like a Fake*, Atlanta: Peachtree Publishers; 1985
- There have been a decent amount of studies done since the 80s
 - 2019: Published by NIH: “Prevalence, Predictors, and Treatment of Impostor Syndrome: a Systematic Review”
 - <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC7174434/>
 - Details 62 studies that have been performed since 1978 on the topic
- Despite the amount of research having been done, not currently formally recognized as a psychiatric disorder.

Impostor Syndrome Cycle



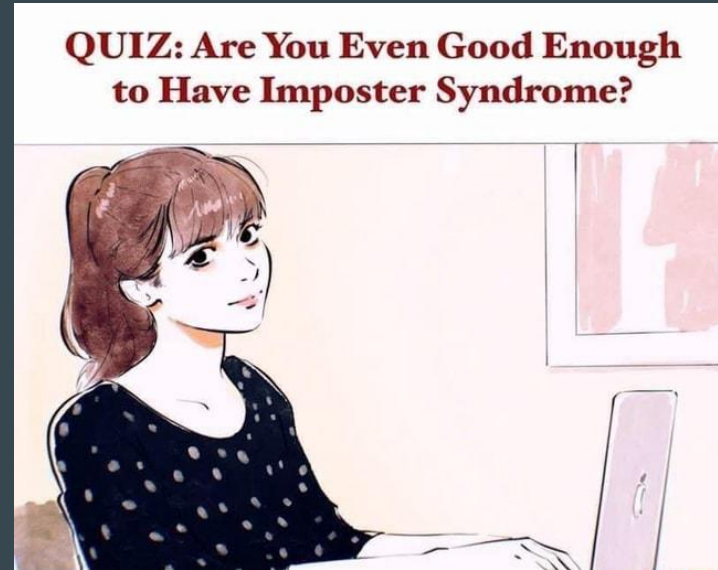
Impostor Syndrome Cousins and Co-morbidities

Friends come in bunches!

- Perfectionism
- Super-Heroism
- Denial of Competence and Capability
- Atychiphobia
- Achievemephobia

Other fun symptoms

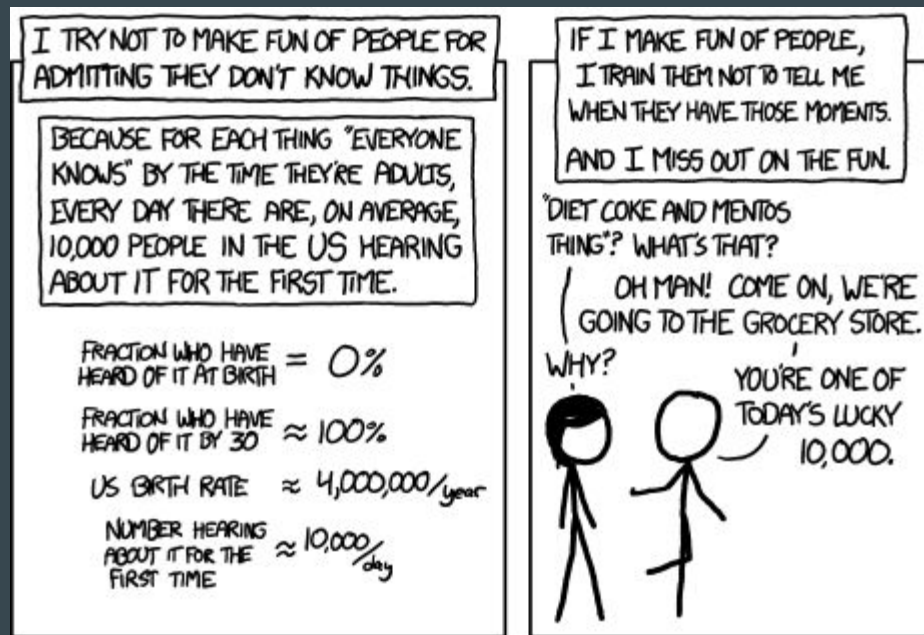
- Anxiety Disorders
- Depression
- Burnout



Why does Impostor Syndrome affect IS professionals?

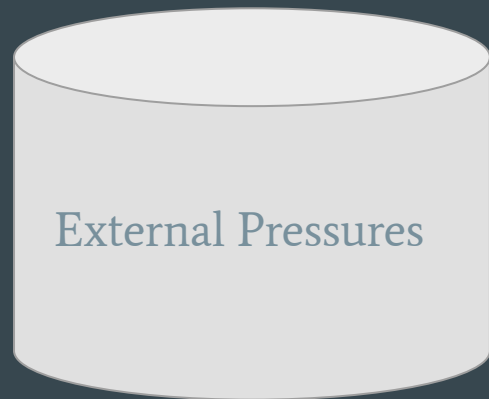
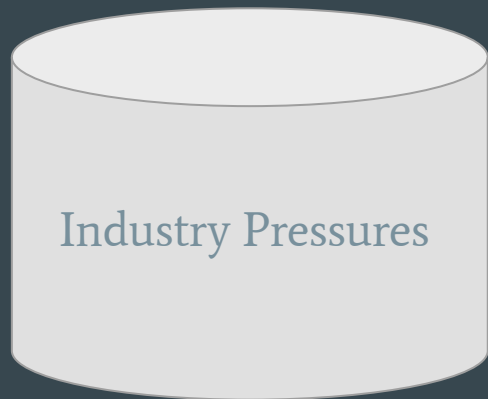
Who Impostor Syndrome affects

- In short, Any “High-Functioning” adults
- Much of written literature has focused on medical professionals or general business professionals
- More recently, thought leaders in our industry have started to talk about it.
- Obviously being who I am, I cant speak to the experience of others in the Information Security community



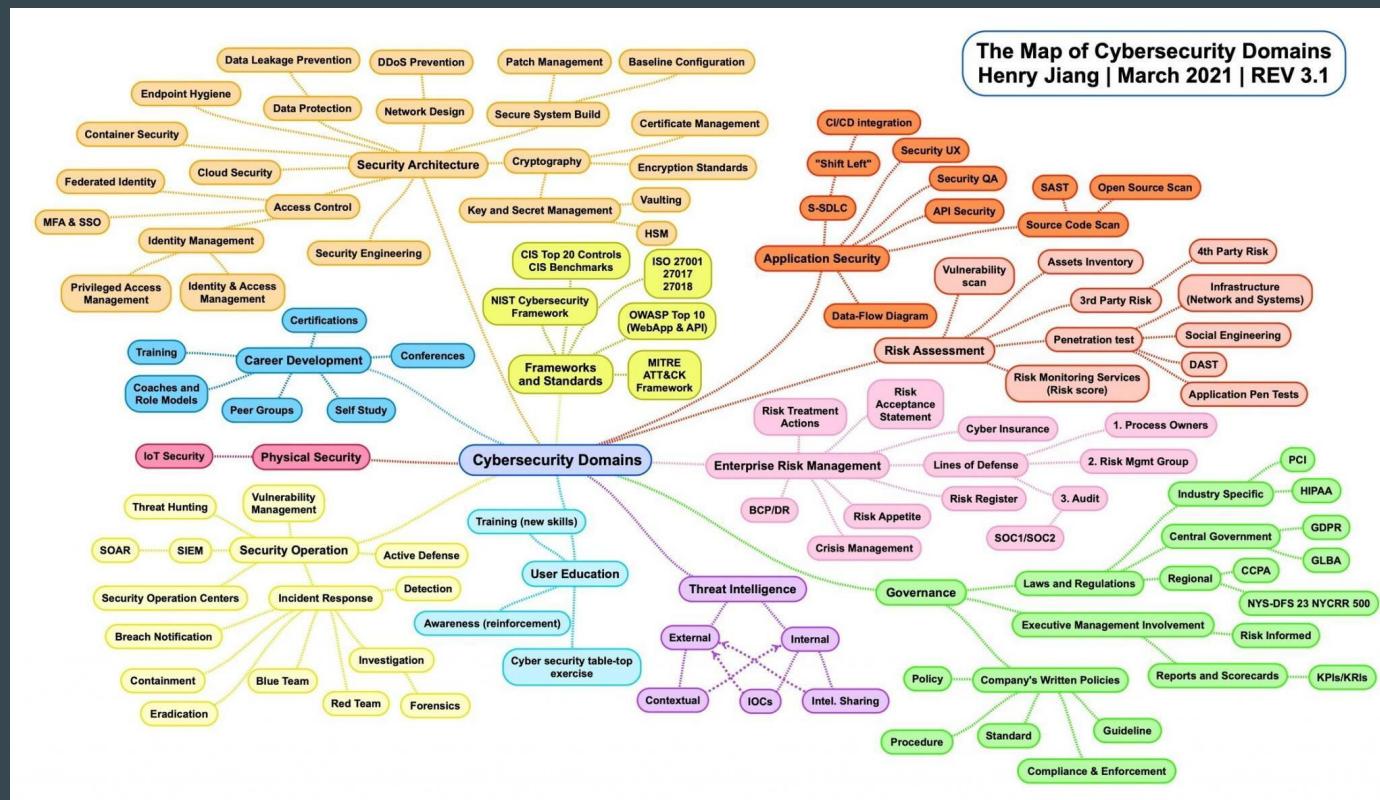
Why Impostor Syndrome in Infosec

Boiled down to 3 pressure buckets



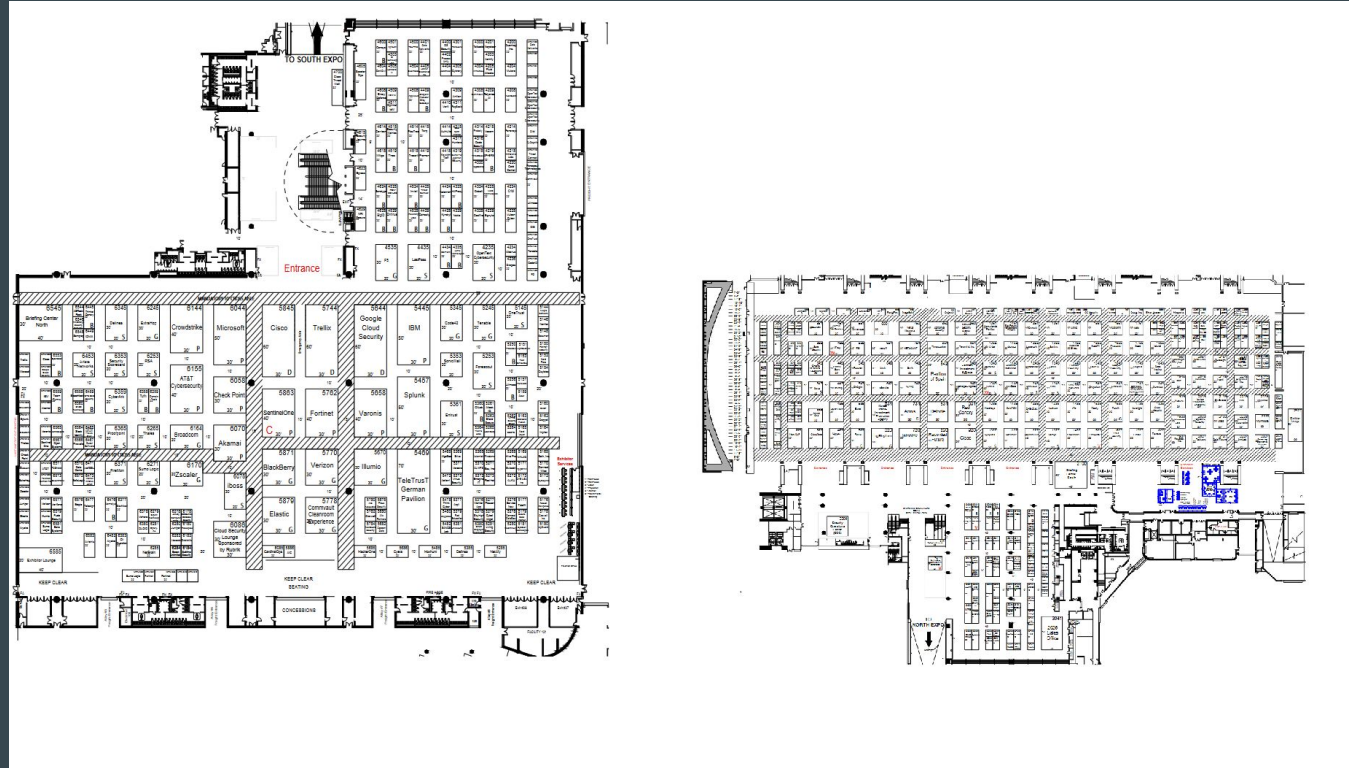
Industry Pressures

Let me show you 3
different *incomplete*
maps:



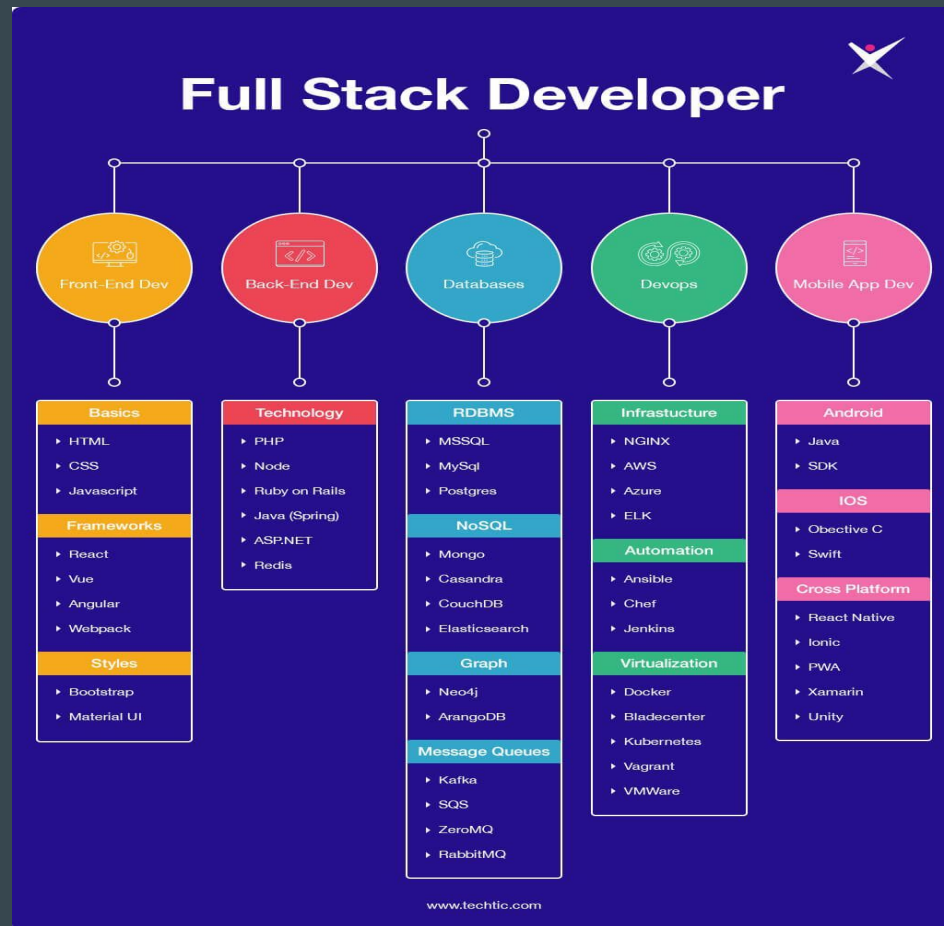
Industry Pressures

Map #2:



Industry Pressures

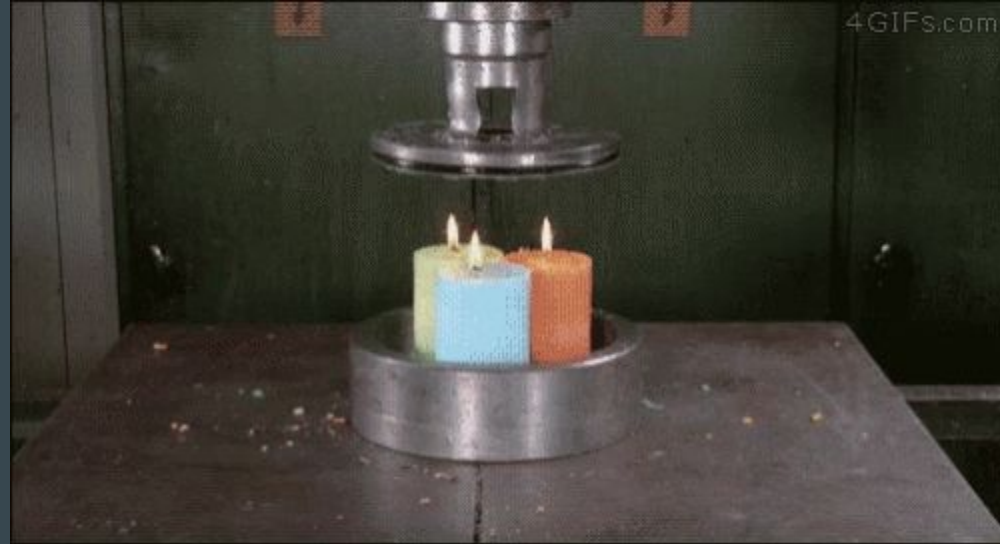
Map #3



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Organizational Pressures

- Job Performance
 - Sense of pride with regards to job
 - Performance against Expectations
- Team Size/Workload
 - Correlation between stress and workload
 - Team member numbers are important
- Work/Life Balance
- Playing the Corpo Game



External Pressures

- Always a new threat actor
- ...or vector
- ...or threat
- Normal life stuff...

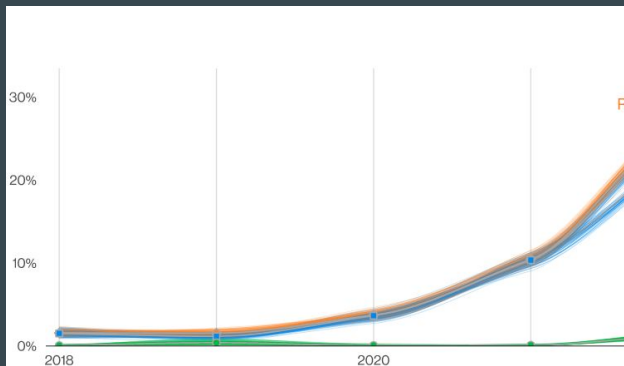
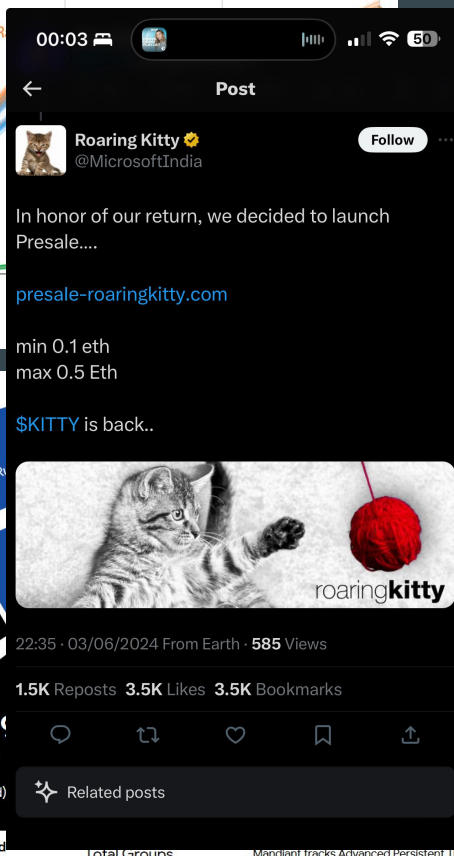
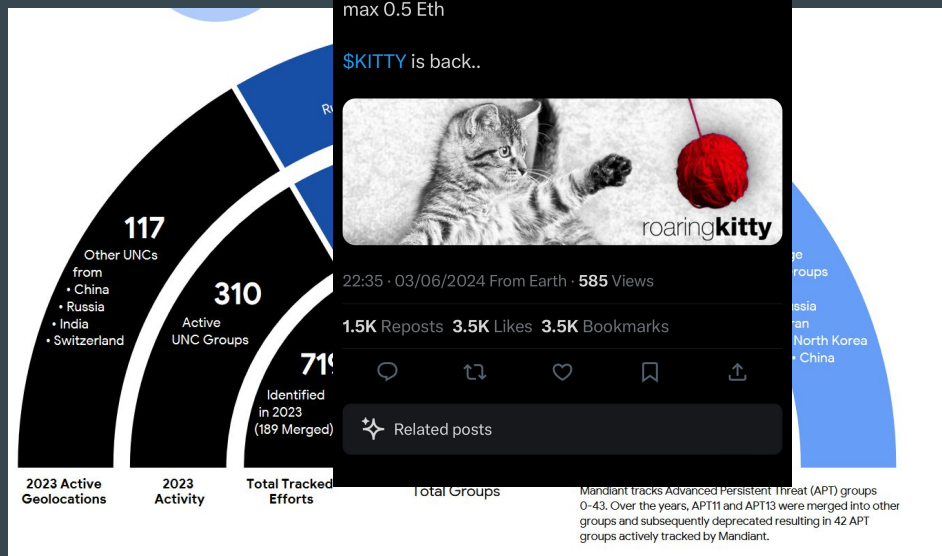


Figure 2. Ransomware and Extortion breaches over time



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How do we win?



- Focus on yourself and your career/interest
 - Find your Niche!
- Don't "Fake it til' you make it"
- Presenting yourself
- Stop comparing yourself to others

Winning Continued

- Chat with colleagues
- Therapy is great!
- Take your timeoff
- Take note of your accomplishments
 - Stick a pin here! ✨



What is this about a hacker grimoire?

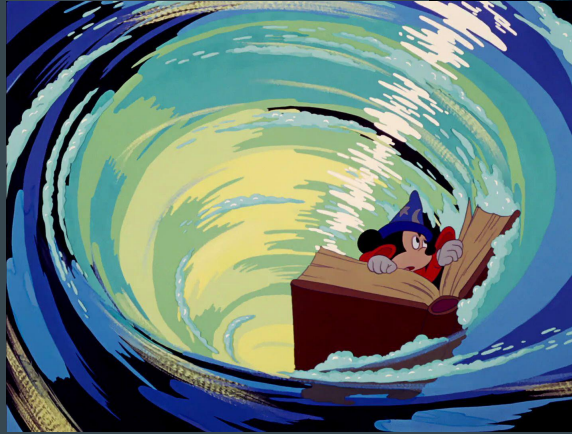
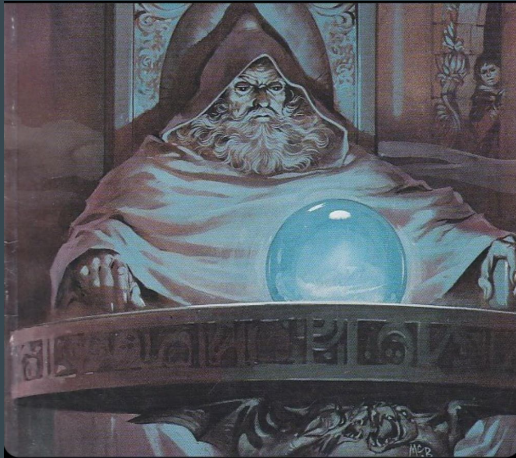
What the heck is a grimoire? (grəim'wär)

- “A magician's manual for invoking demons and the spirits of the dead”
- Term is derived from old french:
 - alteration of *gramaire* grammar, grammar book, learned work, book of witchcraft
 - Was used to describe books that were written in Latin
- In 1801 English Occultist Francis Barrett used the term in his book *The Magus* and...



The Grimoire in Popular Culture

- Obviously has shown up a bunch in traditional fantasy with wizards consulting a Grimoire



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Let's talk about Clarke for a minute

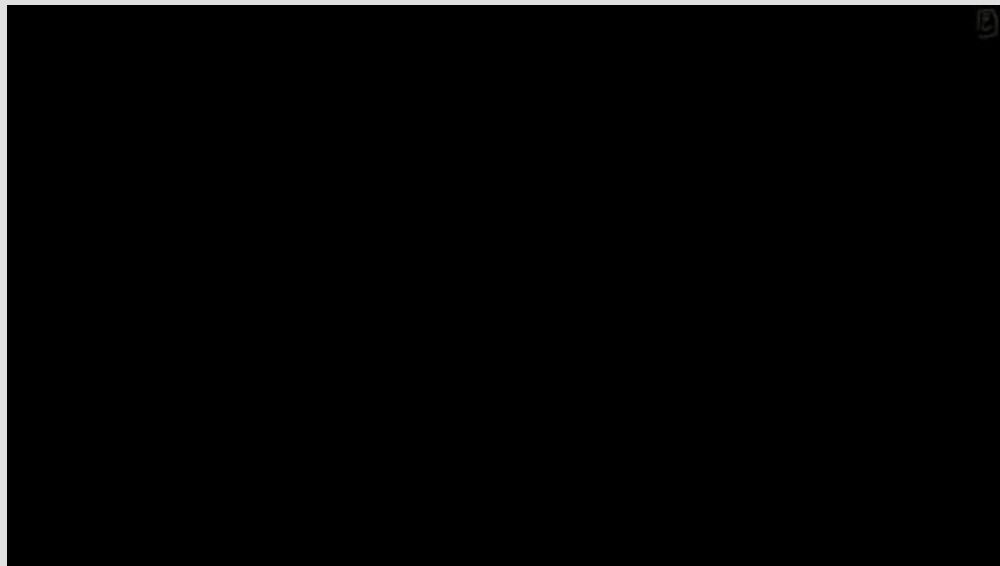
Sir Arthur C. Clarke, one of the most prolific Sci-fi writers ever had 3 adages he followed extensively in his writing:

1. When a distinguished but elderly scientist states that something is possible, he is almost certainly right. When he states that something is impossible, he is very probably wrong.
2. The only way of discovering the limits of the possible is to venture a little way past them into the impossible.
3. Any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from **magic**.



So, then...

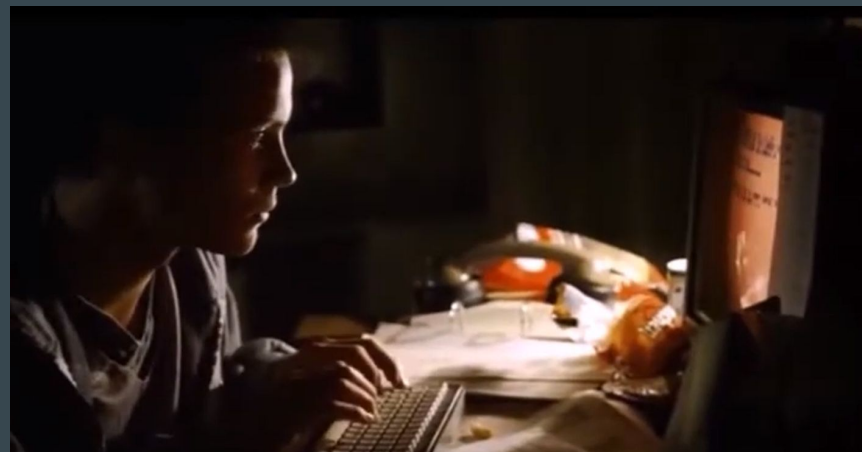
Let's be wizards.



The Grimoire in (Pop)hacker culture

While maybe we haven't specifically acknowledged it...

- Sneakers: "Setec Astronomy"
- 23 - Nichts ist so wie es scheint
 - (Not the Jim Carrey Film)
- Swordfish *bit of a stretch but why not



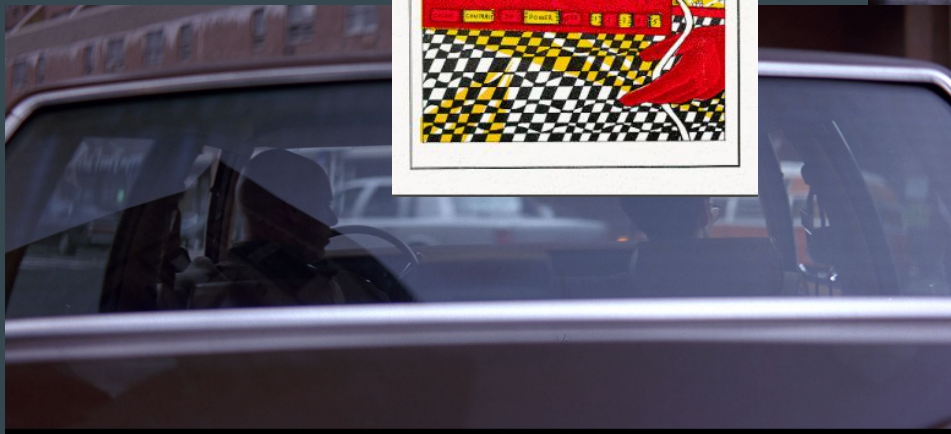
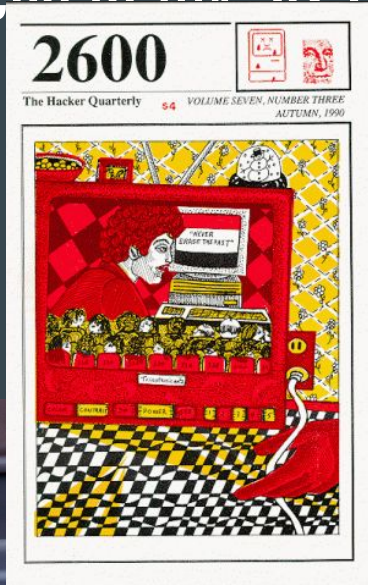
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And of course, Hackers...

A scene inside the Cyberdelia nightclub...



Pivot to the end of my Six Degrees of Kevin Bacon



2600: The Hacker Quarterly



*First published in 1984

*Publisher Emmanuel Goldstein was a non-credited consultant on *Hackers*

Bringing it full Circle

Volume Twenty-Seven, Number Two, Summer
2010 article of 2600 The Hacker Quarterly.

Penname - Leviathan

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WHY YOU NEED A GRIMOIRE

by Leviathan

No matter how long you have been hacking, surfing, or working in IT, and especially in these uncertain times when your activity can be sniffed, parsed, logged, and archived, you need a grimoire.

Dictionary.com defines a grimoire as "a manual of black magic (for invoking spirits and demons)." Those of us who have been pushing bits around for some time know that the things we routinely accomplish can sometimes appear to be black magic to the less technically adept among us. The sheer volume of information we have stuck in our craniums and bookmarks, and our ability to Google with precision, gives us an edge in finding and implementing all sorts of technology magic. This is all good.

But it's not perfect, you know. We forget things. A website that we KNOW contained the answer last week, is suddenly gone. The transient nature of that big beast we call the Internet means that all content is in flux. And by the way, are you tired of the many tech support sites, powered by ad after ad, where you have to register before they'll let you click on the answer to your question?

To paraphrase Dennis Hopper: "You, my friend, you need a grimoire."

To the uninitiated, it looks just like a plain, bound notebook. But to you, and to the minions who watch in awe as you use it, it is truly a book of spells. You have the answers, because everything of value you've come across in your technology dealings, you've recorded faithfully in your grimoire.

A grimoire is not pretty. It's not always well-organized. But the answers are there, because you put them there. It's your insurance policy, your journal, your database. In time you will come to know exactly where everything is.

Best of all, it's private. No amount of ISP chicanery, keystroke logging, or site mirroring will ever create another copy of your grimoire. It will never slip you a cookie or prompt you to install another damned plug-in.

That, ummm, marginal URL that you really don't want in your bookmarks? Into the grimoire it goes. Default (factory) passwords? Never know when you'll need those. Write 'em down.

That UNIX command with a mile-long, unreadable `man(1)` page? Write down exactly

how you use the command in real life, using only the options that are most useful to you. That unsupported hack that made your video card come alive... what happens if you have to reload the OS? Catalog it with care.

Account names and passwords: be careful here. Most of us have a handful of good, strong passwords we use all the time. Write down only the first two or three characters, and fill in the rest with random letters. Same with user IDs. No unintended reader will ever determine your complete password from `w9xxxxxxx`. But knowing the starting letters will allow you to remember it.

And while that high-priced storage specialist is on site, why not make a few notes while looking over her shoulder? Phone numbers, support contracts, public keys, small but valuable scripts; these are all good candidates for your personal archive.

Now this part should be obvious: my grimoire goes everywhere I go, no exceptions. It's always available to me regardless of where I am or what other resources there are.

If you accumulate as much information as I have (my grimoire is about twelve years old, with new entries written in the margins now), you and your book will become the stuff of legends. When I walk into a meeting and put it down on the table, I inevitably get the question, along with a stare of admiration: "Is that the book?" I smile in reply.

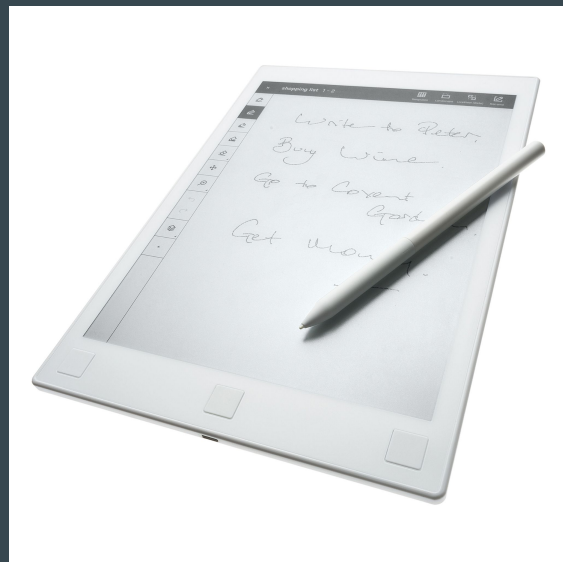
And if, saints forbid, you should ever be in an embarrassing legal situation and you have to get rid of its evidence quickly, tear out the offending pages, shed a few tears, then flick your Bic. Let's see you clean up a hard drive that cleanly. Privacy, my friends, it is priceless. If your dealings are not quite that dramatic, your grimoire is a good reference at review time or when preparing your resume.

So spend a few wise dollars and obtain a good quality, bound notebook with lined archive paper, and start filling it with your accumulated IT wisdom. You and your grimoire will make history.

A salute to all my mates, in the gutter and among the stars. I also want to thank everyone who had kind words for my short story, "The Particle," that appeared in 26:1. Though it was fiction, you'd never believe the parts that were based in fact.

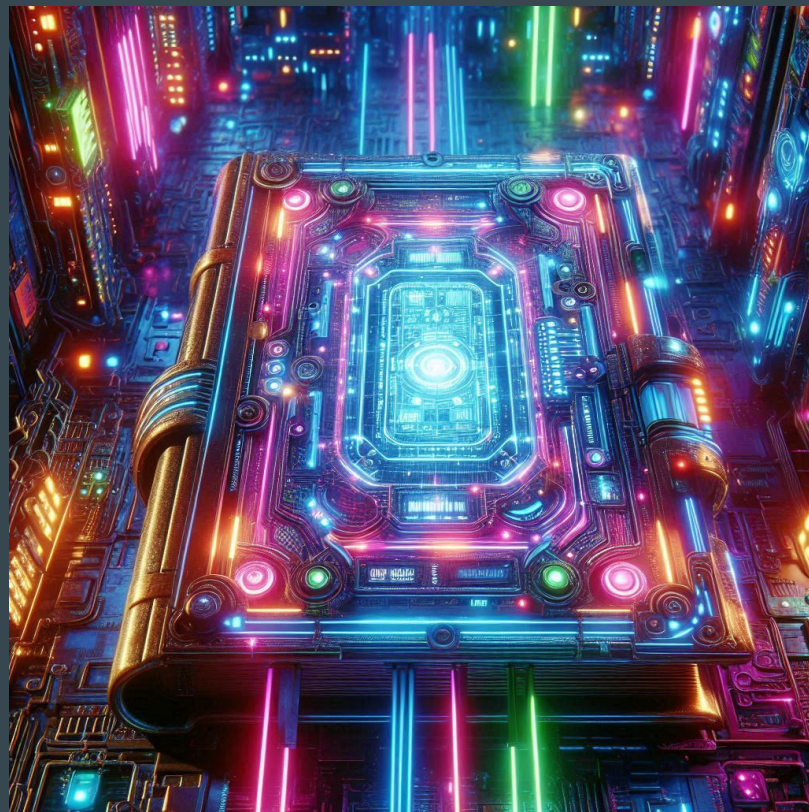
My experience

- In past, mostly digital but I am a disorganized mess
 - Have bounced between physical and Digital a bunch
- Currently physical...but I am still a disorganized mess.
- Open to/looking into more recent technologies



The Hacker Grimoire defined/refined

- A personal repository of technical or information with some amount of structure.
 - Making it personal == hack to force yourself to use it.
- Doesn't /specifically/ have to be digital or physical
 - Stick in pin in this.
- Should be easy to access without delay.
 - It is your spellbook after all.



Dont's and Do's

Dont:

- Obvious stuff
 - Passwords*
 - Gray Area things
- Less Obvious
 - Use acronyms that aren't defined or obvious
- Avoid code to an extent
 - Especially if you go the pen & paper route

Do's

- Shorthand
 - Acronyms if consistent are good actually
- Note your accomplishments! ✨
- Reference other documents
 - Things like internal documentation
 - But take caution
- Take it everywhere you can

Institutional Knowledge



- One thing that every company struggles with..
- I think encouraging employees to make their own grimoires is a really good idea
- Giving employees a platform to do this is ok, but be weary

Peek at a page

Wrapping things up

- Impostor Syndrome is legit and totally normal
- You aren't alone in dealing with it
- We should really embrace being the Wizards we all are.



Contact me! ShoutOuts!

Hit me up on Mastodon @[vgzbrennan@infosec.exchange](https://infosec.exchange/@vgzbrennan)

Shout outs to

My partner for her support

The Stall-3 crew and vgz.cx

The community on infosec.exchange especially its operator
@jerry.

@deviantollam

@[realhackhistory@chaos.social](https://chaos.social/@realhackhistory)

@[thegibson@hackers.town](https://hackers.town/@thegibson)

Thanks!

Sources

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- <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC7174434/>
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- <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/grimoire>
- **Volume Twenty-Seven, Number Two, Summer 2010 article of 2600 The Hacker Quarterly.**
 - **Reposted @ <https://advancedphotosolutions.blogspot.com/2010/07/why-you-need-grimoire.html>**

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